

September 10, 2026: Whether It Happened or Not

“Memories of childhood were the dreams that stayed with you after you woke.”

— Julian Barnes

“It’s all true, whether it happened or not.”

— Kent Allen



This might be one of my earliest memories, sitting with my three siblings (two more appeared later.) for this picture. I remember being lifted up and placed next to Chris to prevent me from falling forward or back. I remember Dad perched on the wall behind us; so much more than a backstop... but that too. I'm guessing from the picture that I was probably two years old---maybe three. I can't trust my memory on any of this, and neither should you; but in my mind it was taken on the granite wall at Fort Preble near Spring Point Light. If the picture was really taken where I *think* it was, those stones are now toppled by the Christmas Day storm a decade or so ago. I can't go back.

Of course, I can't remember any of the words that Dad might have spoken, but if he said anything at all, I imagine it was “pipe down you birds!” or “look sharp swabbies”, or something along those lines. I do remember Mom stepping forward to re-tie my shoes... whether that happened or not, I remember it vividly. And, I remember Chris keeping me steady; he's still good like that. All the details may be manufactured in my mind by prompts captured in the photo. But I'm sure I recall the very real feeling of risk and adventure sitting on that stone with my back to the sea. I remember the sense of being included, and safe and trusting and proud that Dad had lifted me up, placed me in the foreground (well, the front row anyway), and brave because he was both behind me and beside me. To that feeling- to that truth- I can go back again and again with confidence.

Dad didn't tell me how to be or live so much, but he let me be with him and watch and learn how he was. He didn't try to make me become another version of him, but he didn't try to hide his light either. He still shines, and it's reflected in all the faces of my family!

Happy Thinksday